

언어 속 문화 읽기

PRAGMATIC PERSPECTIVES ON LANGUAGE USE

A Sample Dialogue

Situation: Kiki and Sharon are students at a British University. They have been flatmates for a short time and do not know each other very well. Kiki is Greek and Sharon is English. Sharon is getting ready to go out.

- [1] Kiki: Where are you going tonight?
[2] Sharon: Ministry.
[3] Kiki: Ministry?
[4] Sharon: Ministry of Sound. A club in London. Heard of it?
[5] Kiki: I've been clubbing in London before.
[6] Sharon: Where to?
[7] Kiki: Why do you want to know?
[8] Sharon: Well, I may have been there.
[9] Kiki: It was called 'The End'.
[10] Sharon: Nice one!
[11] Kiki: I hope you have a good time at the Ministry.
(contributed by Kelly-Jay Marshall)

Pragmatic Meaning

Pragmatics is concerned with the study of the meaning that linguistic expressions receive in use. So one task of pragmatics is to explain how participants in a dialogue such as the one above move from the decontextualised meanings of the words and phrases to a grasp of their **meaning in context**. This process can involve several aspects:

1) *Assigning Reference*

Kiki starts by asking Sharon where she is going, but Sharon's one-word answer is not informative enough for Kiki to be able to figure out what Sharon is actually referring to. Sharon's utterance takes it for granted that the name '**Ministry**' has a referent (in other words, it presupposes the existence of a referent), but Kiki's general world knowledge is insufficient for her to identify the specific referent that Sharon intended for 'Ministry' in this context. Only upon further clarification (requested in [3] and given in [4]), is Kiki able to work out that, by saying 'Ministry' ([2]), Sharon intends to convey something like: *I am going to a London club called 'Ministry of Sound'*. So, there is a **gap** between **the decontextualised meaning** of the utterance (roughly, what the word 'Ministry' means according to the dictionary) and **the thought** expressed by that word (roughly: a London club called 'Ministry of Sound'). Kiki needs to bridge this gap, and initially fails to do so. In other words, **a listener needs to assign reference to the words that a speaker uses**, and since there is no direct relationship between entities and words, the listener typically has to make inferences as to what the speaker intends to identify.

2) Inferring Illocutionary Force

Another perspective on meaning in communication focuses on the distinction between the linguistic form of the utterance and its communicative function (technically, the **illocutionary force*) of that utterance in the communication situation. Let us consider Kiki's first question again: [1] "**Where are you going tonight?**" Was she requesting information? Did she intend to hint that she wanted to be invited out with Sharon? Or was she perhaps criticizing Sharon for going out too much? In other words, what was her intention in using an interrogative utterance, or more technically, what was the illocutionary force (request for information (?), suggestion/hint (??)) of Kiki's interrogative utterance?

*The philosopher John Austin (1962) generated, and another philosopher of language John Searle (1969) developed the view that language should be seen as a form of action – that when we speak, we '**do**' things like make requests, make statements, offer apologies, and so on. Austin's initial insight was that people do not simply make statements that can be judged as 'true' or 'false'; rather they use language to perform actions (such as requesting information, promising, offering, etc.) that have an impact in some way on the world.

*<3 types of speech acts>

① "I'll turn off the TV" / ② "여기 좀 출지 않아?"

- 1) Locutionary act 발화행위(what was said): ①②문자 그대로의 의미가 담긴 발화 행위/발화 그 자체
- 2) *Illocutionary act 발화의도 행위(what was meant): ①TV를 보면서 형제가 다투고 있는 상황에서 싸우지 말고 잘 보라는 경고 행위/ ②온도 좀 올리자는 요구
- 3) Perlocutionary act 발화효과 행위(what happened): ①싸우지 말라는 경고에 잠잠해진 결과/ ② stove를 켜다.

3) Figuring out what is communicated directly

Sometimes the process of identifying pragmatic meaning involves interpreting vague linguistic expressions in order to establish which concepts and thoughts they express. For example, in line [10] Sharon says "**Nice one.**" This could be taken to mean that a particular previously mentioned thing is nice (in this context, the London club called 'The End'), but this expression also has another conventionalized (and somewhat vague) meaning, roughly: *Good idea, or Well done*. In this dialogue, it is unclear whether Kiki has interpreted the phrase in one way rather than another, or whether she treats both interpretations as possible.

There is a **gap between the meaning** of the words used by the speaker and **the thought** that the speaker intends to represent by using those words on a particular occasion. This gap is filled by the addressee's reasoning about what the communicator (may have) intended to communicate by his or her utterance.